Common Sense

Thomas Paine · January 1776 · excerpts

Source: Thomas Paine, Common Sense (1776), text via Project Gutenberg (#147). Public domain; 1776 spelling retained.

Published anonymously in Philadelphia in January 1776, Thomas Paine's pamphlet sold an estimated 120,000 copies in three months — extraordinary for a colonial population of about 2.5 million. Paine argued in plain language that reconciliation with Britain was impossible and that monarchy itself was illegitimate. The pamphlet helped shift colonial opinion from protest to independence in the months before the Declaration.

Connect: How does Paine's attack on monarchy build on the colonists' grievances from Class 2?

Key Passages

On monarchy

There is something exceedingly ridiculous in the composition of monarchy; it first excludes a man from the means of information, yet empowers him to act in cases where the highest judgment is required. … One of the strongest NATURAL proofs of the folly of hereditary right in kings, is, that nature disapproves it, otherwise she would not so frequently turn it into ridicule by giving mankind an ASS FOR A LION.

On reconciliation

But Britain is the parent country, say some. Then the more shame upon her conduct. … Europe, and not England, is the parent country of America. … Every thing that is right or natural pleads for separation. The blood of the slain, the weeping voice of nature cries, 'TIS TIME TO PART. … there is something very absurd, in supposing a continent to be perpetually governed by an island.

On America's destiny

Freedom hath been hunted round the globe. Asia, and Africa, have long expelled her—Europe regards her like a stranger, and England hath given her warning to depart. O! receive the fugitive, and prepare in time an asylum for mankind. … We have it in our power to begin the world over again. A situation, similar to the present, hath not happened since the days of Noah until now.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Fighting had begun at Lexington and Concord (April 1775), yet many colonists still hoped to reconcile with Britain and blamed Parliament rather than the king.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Ordinary colonists, including farmers, artisans, and laborers; it was written in plain language to be read aloud in taverns and homes.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Thomas Paine, a recent English immigrant and radical, who had seen the British monarchy firsthand and believed all hereditary government was illegitimate.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ practice: Identify ONE specific piece of evidence from Common Sense and explain how it advanced the cause of independence. Page 1 APUSH Class Documents Class 4 - Common Sense
2. Why was Paine's plain, accessible style strategically important in 1776?
3. How does Paine's argument about monarchy connect to the Declaration of Independence six months later?